

Public Narrative Framework

Marshall Ganz Story of Self / Us / Now — adapted for IRN campaigns.

Public narrative translates values into action through story. It answers: Why me? Why us? Why now? Done well, it moves people from passive sympathy to active commitment.

Story of Self — Why YOU?

Why have you been called to this work? What experience shaped your values?

The Challenge	What happened that forced a choice? One specific moment.
The Choice	What did you do? What values drove that choice?
The Outcome	What changed? What did you learn?

Draft your Story of Self (90 seconds max):

TIP: Specificity = credibility. "I was scared" is weak. "I was shaking in the parking lot of the courthouse at 7am" is strong.

Story of Us — Why WE?

Why are we called together? What shared experience or values unite this community?

Shared Experience	What do we all face? What do we have in common?
Shared Values	What do we believe together that calls us to act?
The Us	Who is in this "us"? Specific enough to be meaningful.

Draft your Story of Us (60 seconds max):

Story of Now — Why NOW?

What is the urgent challenge? What happens if we don't act?

The Challenge	What specific threat or opportunity is at hand RIGHT NOW?
The Hope	What specific action can shift this? What does winning look like?
The Ask	What EXACTLY do you want people to do in the next 24–72 hours?

Draft your Story of Now (60 seconds max):

Example Narrative — Tenant Organizing

SELF: "My landlord ignored my heat complaint for two months. My daughter got sick. I almost didn't say anything — I was scared of retaliation. But I did." US: "Half of us in this building have the same story." NOW: "Tomorrow morning we have a meeting with the housing authority. We need 20 people. Will you be one of them?"

NOTE: Narrative is not manipulation — it is translation. Story creates the emotional context in which people make rational choices to act.